



KEY MEDICINAL PLANTS

Of the estimated 500,000 plants on our planet, it is thought that around 10,000 are used regularly for medicinal purposes. The index of Key Medicinal Plants features 100 of the best-known medicinal plants in Latin name order. Many are commonly available and widely used in different herbal traditions around the world, for example German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77) and ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155). Others, such as neem (*Azadirachta indica*, p. 70), from Asia, are key herbs within their native region. A significant proportion of these herbs have been well researched and most are excellent for home use.

PLANT NAMES

The Latin name given is the one by which the plant is most generally known in medical herbalism. If the plant has a Latin synonym, this is provided. The first part of the Latin name designates the plant's genus (sub-family). The second part specifies the species name. In brackets after the Latin name(s) comes the plant's family name, the broader class to which the genus belongs. The plant's common name(s) are beneath the family name. If more than one common name is in popular use, they are listed in order of importance. Where appropriate, the origins of common names are given in brackets.

HABITAT & CULTIVATION

Gives information on where the plant is indigenous, its current distribution, how it is cultivated and harvested, and any preferred growing conditions.

RELATED SPECIES

Provides cross-references and information on related species that are used medicinally or are well known.

KEY CONSTITUENTS & KEY ACTIONS

Lists the key active constituents and the key medicinal actions of the plant on the body in order of importance. *Note* For more information on plant constituents and their actions, see pp. 10–16.

RESEARCH

Provides details of scientific research conducted into the plant, its constituents, and its extracts, including results of any clinical trials. If appropriate, includes herbal practitioners' observations of the plant's known actions and potential new medicinal uses for the herb.

TRADITIONAL & CURRENT USES

Reveals how the plant was used medicinally in the past and how it is used today in different herbal traditions. Examines differences between traditional and current

uses, and shows how scientific research is sometimes confirming the validity of the traditional use and sometimes uncovering completely new applications for the herb. *Note* See Glossary p. 321 for unfamiliar terms.

PARTS USED

Illustrates the parts of the plant used medicinally.

KEY PREPARATIONS & THEIR USES

Features key preparations with details of how they are taken or applied. Gives cautions about using the herb as a medicine and about the plant in general. States if the plant, its constituents, or its extracts are legally restricted.

Note: A self-help use is provided for many preparations. Before attempting any self-help use, it is essential to read the cautions and the information on pp. 290 & 298–299.

CAUTIONS

Gives cautions about using the herb medicinally and about the plant in general. States if the plant, its constituents, or its extracts are legally restricted.

⚠ *Considered safe as a medicine but potentially harmful if used inappropriately. Particular safety issues are listed. Where a plant is listed as "Take only under professional supervision," it is not suitable for home use.*

☠ *Known to be toxic or unsafe as a medicine. Do **not** self-medicate with these plants. Some plants with this symbol may be safely prescribed by experienced healthcare practitioners within a very narrow dosage range. At a higher dose, such plants will be poisonous.*

SELF-HELP USES

Cross-refers to self-help treatments in *Remedies for Common Ailments*. *Note:* Always read the cautions in *Key Preparations & Their Uses* and the information on pp. 290 & 298–299 before using any herb.

